



key areas of the country's defence right from artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled surveillance and satellite imagery to indigenous drones.

Davinder Sandhu, Co-Founder & Chair of consultancy firm Primus Partners India, says India's defence-tech sector is shifting from a PSU-led model to one where start-ups are crucial drivers of innovation, agility, and strategic autonomy. "These start-ups are developing advanced technologies—from AI-driven drones to smart soldier systems—delivering rapid, indigenous solutions that reduce import dependence and strengthen India's defence capabilities."

Alongside ideaForge Technology, start-ups such as IG Drones and NewSpace Research and Technologies were instrumental in providing real-time reconnaissance and unmanned support to the armed forces in Operation Sindoor. Once seen as peripheral innovators, these ventures are now deeply embedded in India's military value chain, the mission demonstrated.

Many of these start-ups owe their existence, at least partly, to government programmes such as iDEX (Ideas for Defence Excellence) and ADITI (Acing Development of Innovative Technologies with iDEX) that are actively nurturing dual-use (military and civilian)